

Drill #2 – Sole Roll Series

Category: Ball Mastery

Focus: Ball manipulation, balance, coordination, change of direction, close control

Level: High School Varsity

Age Group: U14–Varsity

Players: 1–20+ players

Duration: 10–12 minutes

Field Size: 10x10 to 15x15 yard grid

Intensity: Moderate → High

Purpose

The **Sole Roll Series** develops a player's ability to control and manipulate the ball using the bottom (sole) of the foot. The sole is one of the most effective tools for changing direction, protecting possession, and escaping pressure.

Elite players frequently use sole movements because they allow them to:

- Stop the ball instantly
- Change direction quickly
- Shield the ball from defenders
- Create space in tight areas
- Control the tempo of play

This drill builds confidence using the sole of both feet and prepares players for more advanced moves such as pullbacks, V-cuts, and changes of direction.

Equipment

- One soccer ball per player
 - Cones to mark grid
 - Pinnies (optional)
 - Stopwatch (optional)
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Setup

Create a square grid.

Recommended Sizes

Level	Grid Size
Beginner	15x15 yards
Intermediate	12x12 yards
Varsity	10x10 yards

Each player has a ball and moves freely inside the grid.

Example:

15 yards

X X



X X

15 yards

Players should have enough space to perform movements without collisions.

Instructions

Players perform a series of sole-control movements while moving throughout the grid.

Each movement should be performed for **30–45 seconds** before progressing.

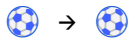
Phase 1 – Forward Sole Rolls

Technique

Players place the sole of the foot on top of the ball and roll it forward.

Movement:

Foot on ball



Players alternate feet.

Coaching Points

- Keep the ball close
 - Roll smoothly, do not push
 - Stay balanced
 - Keep knees bent
 - Move immediately after the roll
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Phase 2 – Backward Sole Rolls

Technique

Players roll the ball backward using the sole.

Purpose:

- Escape pressure
- Create passing angles
- Change direction

Example:

Defender

X



Pull back

Coaching Points

- Drag the ball with control
- Keep body between defender and ball
- Explode away after the movement

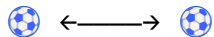
Phase 3 – Side-to-Side Sole Rolls

Technique

Players roll the ball laterally across their body.

Example:

Left Right



Coaching Points

- Stay low
- Move feet quickly
- Keep shoulders relaxed

- Maintain balance
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Phase 4 – Pull-Push Combination

Technique

Player:

1. Pulls ball backward with sole
2. Pushes forward with inside foot
3. Accelerates away

Example:

Pull ↓



Push →

Purpose

This teaches players to escape pressure when receiving with a defender behind them.

Phase 5 – V-Pull

Technique

Player:

1. Places sole on ball
2. Pulls ball backward
3. Pushes diagonally forward

Creates a "V" movement.

Example:



Game Application

Used by:

- Midfielders turning away from pressure
- Wingers beating defenders
- Forwards creating shooting space

Phase 6 – Sole Roll + Inside Touch

Technique

Combination move:

1. Roll ball across body
2. Take inside touch away
3. Accelerate

Example:

Roll



Touch



Coaching Points

The final touch should create separation.

Progression 1 – Increase Speed

Players perform movements faster while maintaining control.

Coach:

"Fast feet, soft touches."

The objective is not speed alone; it is controlled speed.

Progression 2 – Add Direction Changes

Coach calls:

- Turn
- Reverse
- Escape
- Change

Players immediately perform a sole movement and accelerate.

Progression 3 – Add Passive Defenders

Add defenders who apply pressure but do not tackle.

Players must:

- Protect the ball
 - Use their body
 - Escape pressure
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Progression 4 – Competitive Game

Sole Roll Survival

Rules:

- All players have a ball
- Players attempt to knock other balls out
- Players protect their own ball

Last player remaining wins.

Focus:

- Awareness
- Shielding
- Quick sole movements

Coaching Points

1. Soft Contact

The sole should guide the ball.

Avoid stomping.

Good:

- Relaxed foot
- Controlled pressure

Poor:

- Heavy downward force

2. Body Position

Players should:

- Bend knees
 - Stay balanced
 - Keep hips low
 - Be ready to accelerate
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3. Use Both Feet

Many players avoid their weaker foot.

Require:

- Right foot only rounds
 - Left foot only rounds
 - Alternating rounds
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4. Movement After the Skill

A move is useless without acceleration.

Teach:

"Beat the pressure, then explode."

5. Head Up

Players should scan:

Before:

- Where is space?

During:

- Where is pressure?

After:

- Where is next action?
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Common Mistakes

Mistake 1: Standing Still

Problem:

Player performs skill but does not move.

Correction:

Every move ends with acceleration.

Mistake 2: Ball Too Far Away

Problem:

Player loses control after roll.

Correction:

Use lighter pressure.

Mistake 3: Upright Body Position

Problem:

Slow reactions.

Correction:

Lower center of gravity.

Mistake 4: Using Only One Foot

Problem:

Predictable movement.

Correction:

Force weak-foot repetitions.

Coaching Questions

Ask players:

- "Where is your escape route?"
 - "Can you protect the ball?"
 - "What happens after your move?"
 - "Can you change direction without slowing down?"
 - "Which foot gives you the best angle?"
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Varsity Challenge

Pressure Escape

Pair players:

- Attacker starts with ball
- Defender applies pressure from behind

Attacker must:

1. Use a sole movement
 2. Escape pressure
 3. Dribble through a target gate
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Suggested Drill Timeline

Time Activity

2 min Free sole touches

2 min Forward/backward rolls

2 min Side-to-side rolls

2 min Pull-push and V-pulls

3 min Pressure escape

1 min Competitive challenge

Key Coaching Phrase

"Control with the sole. Escape with speed."

Skills Developed

- ✓ Close ball control
- ✓ Change of direction
- ✓ Balance
- ✓ Agility

- ✓ Shielding ability
 - ✓ First touch
 - ✓ Confidence under pressure
 - ✓ Weak foot development
 - ✓ 1v1 attacking ability
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Related Drills:

- Drill #1 – Inside/Outside Touches (ball familiarity)
- Drill #3 – Cone Weave Progressions (dribbling technique)
- Drill #4 – L-Turns and Pullbacks (pressure escape)
- Drill #5 – Shielding Under Pressure (possession retention)